

safeguard the vulnerable Windows-based PCs on your network. In fact, you can even set up your Linux box to be a gateway, and block unwanted visitors.

Post-install

Mandrake and SuSE have some extra configuration options, such as setting up the Internet proxy immediately after installation, and letting you connect to the Internet immediately. Similarly, both allow you to configure your modem during this period. Mandrake allows you to manage the default services that start with operating system, an excellent option for advance users. SuSE offers to help set up DSL, ISDN and VNC.

Only Mandrake, Red Hat and SuSE help you update the latest security patches during install—patches could have been released after the CD was distributed.

Hardware issues

The configuration we used to test the distributions was described earlier. Unfortunately, Lycoris and Xandros refused to install on that system due to poor hardware support. We used an older configuration to test them—a Pentium II 350 MHz on a ZX board with 256 MB SD RAM, LG 48x CD-ROM and a Samsung 20 GB hard drive.

Lycoris has other issues with hardware compatibility. If you have to remove an optical drive time and again, or if you frequently change drive channels—from primary slave to secondary slave, etc., you will have problems accessing your optical drive when running Lycoris.

Using Linux

Only, Red Hat and Mandrake warn you if you try and login as 'root' in GUI mode. This is important, because one mistaken command can damage the OS.

ELX, Red Hat and Xandros have a 'First Run' wizard. In ELX, this

wizard lets you set the default system behaviour, set up the default theme, as well as set up the auto-mount option for Windows partitions, if any. Another interesting feature was 'Eye-O-Candy', this is a slide bar which lets you choose between performance and effects—we recommend the lowest setting for slower processors. Xandros allowed left-handers to set up the default mouse behaviour for themselves. It then let's you set up a dial-up connection, network, printers and system settings. The system settings of ELX and Xandros were the same. Red Hat's First Run wizard helped with configuring the sound card, installing other software from additional CDs (optional), and a patch update via RHN.

Mandrake is a shocker—it starts with an absolutely blank desktop, and doesn't allow right-clicks on the desktop.

Xandros, at the other extreme, supports active user switching, just as in Windows XP.

Applications

Word Processors, Spreadsheets and Presentations are the three most widely used applications for any SoHo user. OpenOffice.org offers a good set of applications for this purpose. All the distributions we tested had the OpenOffice.org suite of applications. The interoperability factor with Windows, in this case Microsoft Office, is properly dealt with.

The two most common messengers that appear were Kopete and Gaim. Both of these messengers are multi-network as they enable a user to login to more than one type of service, including both MSN and Yahoo! Messenger.

Except for Mandrake, which does bundle an MP3 player, all the others had an application to play movies and MP3s. Mandrake can acquire MP3 capability easily, by downloading a plug-in, but then again, it faced problems when configuring the sound card.

All the OSes include a browser, e-mail client and dial-up connection manager. The difference is the particular applications that are bundled. Konqueror or Mozilla are most common, but

Except for Mandrake, these Linux distributions include applications to play MP3s and movies

Xandros also includes Opera 7.5.

All have important tools such as file archiving software, PDF readers, address managers, organizers, and CD or DVD burning software. You can forget about issuing commands to burn CDs or DVDs—thanks to the easy to use K3b GUI application. ELX didn't bundle a fax application such as KFax.

CDs or DVDs burnt on a Linux machine can easily be read on a Windows machine, and vice versa. You may not be able to read an unfinished CD or DVD in Linux, but K3b, the CD burning software, can import a session, and also help you finalise the CD or DVD. CDs burned with the 'track-at-once' option can only be read by K3b, and multi-session CDs burnt with the 'disc-at-once' option can't be read on CD-ROM drives.

SuSE has a taken a different approach towards helping users manage applications. It doesn't show the list of packages as the others do. Instead, it provides a search box—search for a string such as 'ftp', and all packages related to it appear. This list shows both the ones already installed, as well as those that aren't. Additionally, a 'Check Dependency' button helps find components needed by the application. Red Hat follows the same old package manager, which lists packages under groups—finding an individual application needs experience or hard work. Mandrake comes out on the top here—its rpmrake provides the benefits of both SuSE and Red Hat.

CD ripping

There are many open source software available to rip an Audio-CD on to your hard drive. Most distributions—except Xandros—provided one. The most common applications are GUI tools such as grip, KAudioCreator, etc.

SuSE doesn't install the CD ripping tool in the default install, you have to manually install it later. ELX

installs its application in the default install, but the surprise was Red Hat, which doesn't even bundle a GUI-based CD ripping tool.

Multimedia

You'll have a tough time playing DVDs in Linux. Multimedia software such as



The KDE Control Centre takes care of tasks such as configuring a device, or adding removing software